

How Bureaucracies Acquire Information from a Partisan Media Supply

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Abstract

How do bureaucracies seek information? Bureaucrats rely on news media to navigate a complex information environment and make strategic decisions, yet the volume of news is overwhelming. Agencies, therefore, contract private firms to distill news into daily “clipbooks.” I analyze these clipbooks across U.S. executive agencies and find a systematic skew. Conservative news sources appear more often in briefings for conservative agencies like Immigration and Customs Enforcement. The skew does not appear to arise from biased news selection; instead, it mirrors the news supply. Conservative outlets generally produce less content about liberal agencies, and vice versa. Because of this supply asymmetry, liberal agencies receive little news from conservative sources. While the pattern is generally stable across administrations, there is evidence of biased selection during Trump’s second term, representing a clear departure from prior periods. I close by discussing how these disparities in coverage may affect agency decision making and representation.

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1. Introduction

Effective government depends on bureaucrats acquiring accurate and timely political information. Incomplete or biased information can distort how bureaucrats perceive their strategic environment, affecting judgements about other political actors, public opinion, and policy. Yet despite the central role of expertise and information asymmetries in contemporary theories of American bureaucracy (Gailmard & Patty, 2012), we know surprisingly little about how bureaucrats actually acquire information and develop expertise. In this paper, I examine how bureaucracies collect information from news media and investigate whether that collection is systematically skewed.

Across more than 2,000 agency daily news briefings, I find that briefings for liberal agencies contain strikingly little coverage from conservative media. By comparing the articles in these briefings to the supply of news, I show that agencies select left- and right-leaning articles at similar rates. The source of partisan imbalance lies upstream: partisan outlets choose which agencies to cover. Across agencies and time periods, conservative outlets produce less coverage of liberal agencies, and liberal outlets similarly under-cover conservative agencies. In practice, agencies largely collect whatever news is readily available. This pattern is consistent with bureaucratic incentives, as satisfying diverse internal constituencies generally encourages broad and comprehensive information collection.

Although unbiased selection is typically viewed as normatively desirable, this supply-side disparity raises new concerns. Even absent preferential selection, agency information environments may still be systematically distorted. The very system designed to ensure that officials are well-informed can itself filter, distort, or politicize information. These processes matter: the information that reaches federal decision makers determines which actors, issues, and narratives are most visible and shapes beliefs about the larger strategic environment. Even when selection is unbiased, the final product can still provide a partial and incomplete picture of public opinion and the larger political environment.

While the supply of news usually explains partisan variation in agency news briefings,

I find some evidence that changes in agency leadership can affect partisan news collection. Consistent with the second Trump administration’s hostility towards mainstream news media, the composition of Homeland Security briefings dramatically changed after Donald Trump returned to office in 2025. Importantly, agency leadership does not always lead to changes. After Trump’s first election in 2017, the composition of the Department of Interior’s briefings remained relatively stable. Together, these findings suggest that, under certain conditions, individuals involved in news collection will manipulate the partisan content of the briefings.

In summary, while agency news collection has always been shaped by the interaction between media monitoring tools and the media supply, the partisan composition of news in the briefings is usually explained by the supply of news rather than preferential selection. However, in a highly-partisan climate where news has been politicized, agency leadership may prioritize collecting information from likeminded sources.

This paper contributes to the growing literature on news media and political elites (see Green-Pedersen & Stubager, 2010; Karpowitz, 2009; Sevenans, 2017a; Severin-Nielsen et al., 2025; Vliegenthart, Walgrave, Wouters, et al., 2016; Vliegenthart, Walgrave, Baumgartner, et al., 2016; Willis, 2013). I add to this research by revealing that political elites have strong reasons to systematically monitor the news, even absent electoral incentives. More broadly, the findings speak to fundamental questions about political accountability, media effects, and information inequality. Unless we study how elites collect and use news, we will underestimate the role of media in political outcomes. By leveraging a new source of data—administrative records of agency news briefings—this paper provides the first systematic evidence of how bureaucracies monitor the news. Combining qualitative analysis of media monitoring practices with quantitative analysis of briefing content reveals important disparities in the supply of news that have previously gone unrecognized.

2. Background

News contains valuable information, but bureaucrats have limited time to search for and consume it (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015). This problem has been intensified by the rise of the internet and media fragmentation (Bawden & Robinson, 2009). To solve this tradeoff, US agencies and other elite actors optimize information collection by creating daily news compilations—typically called daily news briefings, summaries, or “clipbooks.” The content of these briefings depends on two key factors: (1) an agency’s motives for media monitoring and (2) the underlying supply of news.

2.1. What are daily news briefings?

Like many political elites, federal agencies collect and distribute news.¹ The particular tools used for media monitoring vary depending on exact needs and resources of the user, but all of them involve searching a range of sources for news about specific topics of interest (Sullivan, 2012). Once relevant clips are identified, they are typically organized by story or topic with the most important stories appearing first (Sullivan, 2012).

To better understand the purpose of agency daily news summaries, I submitted Freedom of Information Act Requests (FOIAs) for internal emails, documents, and contracts related to custom daily media monitoring reports. I also reviewed contracts for media monitoring posted on USAspending.gov, examined solicitations for contracts on sam.gov, and searched through online archives where journalists and organizations post FOIA documents.²

¹While federal bureaucracies have more resources than many other elites, legislators and interest groups engage in similar topic-based media monitoring (National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, 2020; Willis, 2013).

²The replication files contain a detailed list of contracts and documents. Many of the reviewed documents were posed on Document Cloud or produced through Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requests.

Today, most large agencies employ third party vendors to compile an electronic daily news briefing or clipbook that is emailed every morning to a large number of staff.³ While government employees consume news outside of clipbooks and briefings, these documents are circulated widely and are consistently produced across a wide set of agencies and time periods. This consistency and ubiquity allows for comparison of government news collection across time and agencies.

The market for custom news reports is dominated by four companies: Bulletin Intelligence/Cision,⁴ Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon. Bulletin Intelligence's early employees were former members of the Reagan White House who had been previously tasked with producing Reagan's news summaries. Based on their websites and other government contracts, Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon are veteran-owned businesses with large military contracts. While Bulletin dominated the market in the 2000s, it began losing contracts to Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon in the mid-2010s. Today, all four companies hold lucrative contracts for agency news briefings.

According to the contracts, news briefings are generally targeted at agency leadership and communications staff. However, the email list often extends beyond these two audiences.⁵ The exact list of email recipients depends on the agency, but based on internal emails and the contracts, briefings are often sent to thousands of employees.⁶ In addition to staff who

³Between 2002 and 2024, at least 26 agencies had contracts for custom media monitoring (USASpending.gov). See also Sullivan (2012, p. 20).

⁴Bulletin Intelligence was acquired by Cision, Inc in 2017 (Bulletin Intelligence, 2025).

⁵In addition to top agency leadership, briefing recipients hold positions related to communications, legislative affairs, intergovernmental affairs, and the budget office.

⁶Homeland Security (DHS) reported approximately 5,000 recipients in 2023, the Nuclear Regulatory Commission reported agency-wide circulation (3,000–4,000 employees) in 2014, and TechMIS reported serving over 50,000 government employees in 2017 (Department of

directly receive the full agency news briefing, some individual departments or offices forward a smaller set of relevant clips to their staff. Employees also forward the news clips as a way of starting policy-relevant conversations.⁷

Agency news briefings are the product of a multi-step process and tailored to the priorities and goals of each agency. First, the contractor and agency decide on a procedure for identifying potentially relevant articles. Usually, this involves selecting a list of news sources to monitor and identifying a set of topics or keywords.⁸ These keywords are used to identify a set of potentially-relevant articles. Next, the contractor applies human judgement and an expert understanding of the agency to sort articles into the appropriate section of the briefing, remove irrelevant or redundant information, and produce a short 1-3 sentence summary of each article.⁹ Each article citation is accompanied by basic metadata about the article, including a link to the full text or video, the authors, and the publication date.

In summary, the content of agency news briefings reflects both a series of choices made by agencies and their contractors and the underlying supply of news. How these choices are made depends on the agency's motives for collecting news.

Homeland Security, 2023; Mains, 2017, p. 5; Nuclear Regulatory Commission, 2014, p. 8).

⁷For example, in an email chain from May 2017, DOI employees discuss how to respond to a local news story about coyote hunting (Foley et al., 2017). In another example from the VA, an employee suggests that an article in the news briefing be sent to the Commissioners prior to an upcoming meeting (Leinenkugel, 2018).

⁸In a 2017 document, TechMIS claims to monitor over 50,500 traditional print and broadcast news sources as well as 400,000 social media accounts or blogs (Mains, 2017, p. 5).

⁹Typically, the articles are then aggregated by 'story.' For each story, only one to four article summaries are provided. For stories picked up by many news organizations, additional articles are cited at the bottom of the story but not separately summarized.

2.2. Why do agencies collect news?

While there is a substantial literature on the importance of information and specialization in US bureaucracies (e.g. Gailmard & Patty, 2012; Workman, 2015), we know surprisingly little about how bureaucrats collect information. Given the rich information content of news, it should not be surprising that bureaucrats invest in news collection. Like many political elites, bureaucrats face critical strategic decisions where success or failure depends on their expectations about other political actors. News contains a wealth of information about the activities and positions of these actors (Cook, 1998). Many agencies also rely on news to monitor the effectiveness of their own communication efforts as well as to gather other policy-relevant information (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015; Bustos, 2021; D. Carpenter, 2014; D. P. Carpenter & Krause, 2012). As a result, they have fundamentally different incentives for consuming news media, relative to the general public. In general, agencies are incentivized to collect a broad selection of media.

For bureaucrats, the value of news is not necessarily tied to perceptions of trustworthiness or factual accuracy. Whereas members of the public tend to seek out news they regard as credible and that aligns with their partisan or ideological leanings (e.g. Guess, 2021; Iyengar & Hahn, 2009; Mangold et al., 2024), bureaucrats generally need to monitor their political adversaries and correct false narratives, leading them to value news from low-quality or untrustworthy sources.¹⁰ Because the content of news and the politicians featured in news varies by partisan slant (Kim et al., 2022), we would expect bureaucrats and the agencies they represent to seek out news from a diverse and comprehensive set of sources.

While an agency’s optimal strategy for news collection will depend on a multitude of factors, their motives for collecting news will generally disincentivize biased selection of

¹⁰In December 2025, a White House spokeswoman succinctly captured this logic, telling the Washington Post “unfortunately we are forced to read Fake News so we know what lies we have to debunk” (Kornfield et al., 2025).

ideologically-aligned news sources. These motives can be sorted into three general categories: (1) monitoring the strategic environment, (2) evaluating agency communications, and (3) gathering policy feedback.

First, agencies use news to monitor their strategic environment. While information may be available through other channels, media coverage is often the most straightforward and efficient means of finding out what is going on in politics (Cook, 1998). It is not a coincidence that news collection has been a critical part of open source intelligence collection for over a century (Van Puyvelde & Rienzi, 2023).¹¹ In addition to monitoring external actors, agency leaders use news to monitor their own agencies and reduce agency loss through “reality testing” (Burke & Greenstein, 1989; Karpowitz, 2009).¹² All media monitoring contracts require that briefings contain coverage of the agency, and most specify that the briefings will be used to keep their staff and leadership broadly informed about developments outside of their agencies.¹³ Often, agency briefings have dedicated sections for national news or sections for news about other institutions like Congress, the White House, or the Supreme Court.¹⁴

¹¹Importantly, intelligence collection is not limited to newspapers in countries with free press. Even in the most highly censored, repressive regime, news coverage contains information relevant to predicting the government’s future actions.

¹²See also the literature on censorship and authoritarian regimes (Distelhorst, 2013; Lorentzen, 2014).

¹³For example, in its media monitoring contract, the Nuclear Regulatory Commission (NRC) states that its “officials and staff must start each day fully informed about local, regional, national and international news that is of interest to, or could impact, the NRC (Nuclear Regulatory Commission, 2014, p. 5).

¹⁴For example, the Department of Interior requires a ‘national news’ section in their briefing “suitable to the needs of Department Officials who must be kept aware of important developments affecting the federal government broadly so they can interact with peers in

Second, media contains information critical to evaluating an agency’s communications and public relations efforts. An agency’s reputation is a vital strategic asset that can be used to manage internal and external threats (Bustos, 2021; D. P. Carpenter & Krause, 2012). Almost every contract connects news monitoring to communications or public relations, and many specify that they are interested in monitoring “public interest” in the agency or a “larger public conversation.”¹⁵ In addition to protecting their reputations, agencies with strong communications capacities are better positioned to advance policy goals and core missions.¹⁶ This is evident in contracts from both public-facing agencies like the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA)¹⁷ and those that primarily interact with other institutions, such as the Drug Enforcement Agency (DEA).¹⁸

the administration and congress” (Department of the Interior, 2021, p. 2). Similarly, the Department of Justice requires a section on ‘Administration, Congress, and Supreme Court’ (Justice Management Division of the Department of Justice, 2012, 2018, 2022).

¹⁵For examples, see Environmental Protection Agency (2016); Small Business Administration (2022); Drug Enforcement Agency (2019); Nuclear Regulatory Commission (2014). For bureaucrats with limited direct feedback mechanisms, media coverage can serve as an important indicator of public sentiment. Surveys of bureaucrats have found that career civil servants are attentive to media portrayals of their agency’s work (Karlsen et al., 2020).

¹⁶See also Cook (1998), who argues that news can help agencies achieve policy goals (p. 148-149). Emergency communications is another case where communications effectiveness has been linked to policy outcomes (Bonnevie et al., 2021; Environmental Protection Agency, 2016; Miller & Goidel, 2009; Prue et al., 2003; Small Business Administration, 2022).

¹⁷For the VA, communication is critical to informing veterans and their families about available benefits and programs (Department of Veterans Affairs, 2013).

¹⁸The DEA promotes its mission by raising public awareness about U.S. drug laws and their consequences (Drug Enforcement Agency, 2019, pp. 4–5).

Third, news can play a role in policy feedback and provide other information relevant to policymaking. While information about their strategic environment and communications effectiveness can have policy implications, the news media plays other, more direct roles in policymaking. In their contracts, the Consumer Product Safety Commission¹⁹ and Department of Labor²⁰ describe using the media to monitor for ‘fire alarms’ (McCubbins & Schwartz, 1984).²¹ More generally, media can influence policymaking by shaping how the government detects and defines policy problems (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015).

Together, these motives will generally push agencies to search widely for relevant news, collecting articles from a wide range of sources and perspectives. While an individual bureaucrat may disproportionately value a particular type of information, agency news briefings are designed to satisfy multiple audiences and purposes within the agency. The relative importance of these motives may shift an agency’s optimal monitoring strategy, but systematically favoring ideologically-aligned sources is unlikely to satisfy all of the constituencies within an

¹⁹The CPSC’s contract explains that “Emerging hazards identification, remedial strategy analysis, and regulatory development activities are built upon timely receipt, review, and analysis of news clips covering incidents occurring throughout the country” and that due to past news briefings, “serious product-related accidents reported by the news media have been brought to the attention of the Commission” (Consumer Product Safety Commission, 2020, pp. 4–14).

²⁰The DOL contract says, “news clips serve as an alert to emerging issues, leads for potential DOL investigations, and information that can be shared internally about ongoing programs or activities...[clips] point to problem areas that DOL agencies may need to address” (Department of Labor, 2020, p. 5).

²¹Scholars of authoritarian regimes have similarly recognized the value of media as a feedback mechanism, noting that censorship can be costly because it deprives governments of information (Distelhorst, 2013; King et al., 2013; Lorentzen, 2014).

agency.

While the agency as whole might benefit from a broad approach to news selection, it is possible for the briefings to be influenced by the interests of individuals within the agency. The contracts and internal emails suggest that the final composition of the briefings is a result of an incremental process where some individuals and groups have greater input. Contractors learn what to include in the news summaries by talking with agency staff and getting continuous feedback from various individuals at the agency (see Joshua, 2018). Research on the mass public shows that people tend to prefer news sources aligned with their partisan leanings (Guess, 2021), raising the possibility that similar preferences among agency staff could shape the briefings’ content, even unintentionally.

Under some circumstances, agency leaders may also take steps to intentionally alter the information available to their staff. Two incidents during the first Trump administration suggest that other considerations can dominate the needs of some constituencies within an agency. In the first case, Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) leadership prioritized controlling the flow of information within the agency over maximizing the value of the news briefing to the EPA as a whole. In 2017, EPA leadership first pressured and then fired Bulletin Intelligence during a dispute about negative coverage of EPA leadership in the daily news briefing.²² In the second case, the Department of Justice (DOJ) fired its contractor after employees complained to reporters about “a blog post from a white nationalist website [VDare] that used an anti-Semitic slur” (Barrett, 2019). While some parts of the agency might benefit from following a white nationalist news source,²³ the value was not large enough to outweigh the costs imposed on other employees and risk of additional negative

²²In emails, staffers complained about sending negative stories about their leader to “everyone” (Choma & Leber, 2016; Leber et al., 2017), claimed that the stories were “junk” or “fake” news (Benton, 2017; Ericksen, 2017a), and argued that Bulletin couldn’t provide real-time alerts (Ericksen, 2017b).

²³Benkler et al. (2018) document that popular far-right sources like Brietbart pick up

news coverage (see also Aleaziz et al., 2019). While the motives were different, both agencies narrowed the scope of their news briefings to control what stories circulated.

In summary, news collection within agencies is the product of multiple motives and goals. The final product will depend on the supply of relevant news and key decisions during the news selection process. As a whole, agencies should actively seek out news from all partisan or ideological perspectives. However, when we consider the agencies as collections of individuals with their own biases and incentives, there are scenarios where individual biases or motives could affect news selection.

3. Methods

Previous attempts to study elite news consumption relied on interviews and surveys (Kingdon, 1992; Sevenans et al., 2016; Sevenans, 2017a, 2017b). However, surveys and interviews may underestimate the role of news (Kingdon, 1992, pp. 59–60). Elite recollection of media consumption may be inadequate when they regularly review large volumes of information from a wide variety of sources. In such contexts, self-reports may fail to capture the scope and nature of news exposure. While internal government records have limitations, they offer a more detailed and verifiable foundation for studying elite communication.

To examine the balance of partisan news in agency news briefings, I first categorize the sources cited in agency news briefings. To assess whether the ideological biases of agency staff affect the selection of news, I compare news collection across liberal and conservative agencies and across Democratic and Republican presidential administrations. I also compare the agency news briefings to the news supply.

stories from VDare and circulate them to a wider audience (p. 124). Monitoring VDare would alert the DOJ to potentially damaging or inflammatory stories before they are picked up by other parts of the conservative media ecosystem.

3.1. Daily News Briefs

For this paper, I collected custom news briefings produced for US executive agencies by private contractors.²⁴ To identify contractors, I used USAspending, which is the US government’s official database of federal spending information.²⁵ After identifying contractors, I searched publicly-available databases and submitted FOIAs for briefings produced by the contractors. I selected four sets of briefings where I had more than 30 copies of briefings from multiple presidential administrations. Collectively, these briefings were produced for four agencies by three different third-party contractors under four presidential administrations.

Department of Homeland Security (DHS) and US Citizenship and Immigration Service (USCIS) – The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) is responsible for policy areas and agencies related to immigration, security, and terrorism. The US Citizenship and Immigration Service (USCIS) is a sub-agency of DHS tasked with administering the US naturalization and immigration system. Webpages for TechMIS-produced USCIS and DHS news briefings are indexed and can be found through a search engine like Google. Although USCIS is a subagency of DHS, the briefings are separate. USCIS and DHS have separate contracts with TechMIS. In total, I collected all USCIS briefings from February 1, 2022 through November 5, 2025 ($n=922$) and all DHS briefings from January 2, 2024

²⁴FOIA requests and database search queries need to be specific. Reports produced by third parties were relatively easy to identify because third-party contractors use consistent naming conventions across their reports and often include their company name in their reports.

²⁵I searched USAspending for media monitoring contracts, focusing on contracts for custom media monitoring reports. In total, I identified relevant contracts for 26 federal agencies. On average, each contract is worth approximately \$200,000 per year.

through November 5, 2025 ($n=655$).²⁶ In both briefings, the citations contained hyperlinks. I identified sources by extracting the URLs and hyperlink text. A small number of cited articles were excluded from the analysis because they did not have URLs or identifiable names.

Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) – The Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) provides healthcare and benefits for US military veterans and their families. Barbaricum-produced VA daily news briefings from June 3, 2020 through February 25, 2021 are available through the VA History Office’s Covid-19 archive ($n = 233$).²⁷ Like the DHS and USCIS briefings, I extracted hyperlinked URLs to identify cited articles.

Department of the Interior (DOI) – The US Department of Interior (DOI) is responsible for numerous policy areas relating to national parks, wildlife, Native Americans, energy, and US territories. Unlike the other agencies, the DOI sample is not complete. To identify DOI briefings, I searched an online archive where journalists and interest groups post FOIA-produced documents. In total, I discovered 213 copies of DOI daily news briefings produced by Bulletin Intelligence between February 19, 2015 and November 13, 2018 ($n = 213$). Because the DOI briefing sample depends on journalist and interest group FOIAs, I only have briefings that mention certain keywords. While this could introduce bias, it is unlikely that sampling bias explains the results.²⁸

Because the hyperlinks were stripped from the pdfs, identifying the DOI sources required

²⁶USCIS briefings are only produced for weekdays (Monday-Friday). DHS briefings are produced for all days of the week, excluding federal holidays.

²⁷The archive contains all VA briefings from June 3, 2020 through January 2021. Some of the February 2021 briefings are missing from the archive.

²⁸If selection on particular FOIA topics affect a result, the result would vary over time because the FOIA topics change over time. To test for sampling bias, I verify that my results are consistent across the whole time period covered by the briefings (see Figure A20).

a different process. To convert the DOI briefings into structured data, I used the Gemini 2.0 Flash large language model (LLM) to identify all news sources in the briefings and extract the original text for each source, including any typos (see Appendix A.1). I manually reviewed the resulting list of text snippets, removed misidentified sources, and added website domains. I then split the documents by heading and searched each section for the source text snippets.²⁹ To categorize each source and add source domains, I cleaned the text snippets, merged them with names of US news sources from ABYZ News Links, and filled in missing information based on my own review of the news source.³⁰

3.2. Categorizing Sources

To evaluate the balance of agency news diets, I categorized sources by partisan slant, which is the degree that a source’s reporting generally reflects a particular political affiliation or ideological leaning. I replicated the results in this paper using three different measures of partisan slant; however, I only report the Media Bias/Fact Check (MBFC) scores in the main paper because they are the most complete and missingness is uncorrelated with agency ideology.³¹ Regardless of the measure, the news briefings tend to contain more center or

²⁹Rather than search the full text, I only searched 10 word chunks preceding each forward parenthesis (“(”). In the document text, news source names were almost always followed by descriptive information enclosed in parentheses.

³⁰ABYZ News Links (abyzlinks.com) has been used in other research, including Lutscher (2023) and Matter & Widmer (2021), and has been used by Media Cloud to identify news sources (Media Cloud Blog, 2020). ABYZ News Links categorizes news sources by location, geographic scope, media type, media focus, and language.

³¹Two of the sources—Media Bias/Fact Check (MBFC) and Allsides—use human coders to assign partisan slant scores, and Guess (2021) estimates slant based on website audience. See Appendix A.1 for more details about the partisan bias measures. See also Figure A2.

liberal-leaning news, although there is variation across agencies and briefings.

When analyzing partisan bias, I excluded three types of sources: local general interest news sources (25.5%), government websites (0.2%), and sources with no identifiable URLs or names (0.1%).³² Local general interest sources are defined by their geographic scope, prioritizing news and stories that directly impact the residents of the community they serve.³³ These stories can include national politics, but they more often cover topics like local and state politics, local sports, and entertainment. General interest local sources were dropped because the MBFC scores were less complete for local news sources and there was less agreement between the MBFC and Allsides scores for local general interest sources (see Table A1). In the Appendix, I show that the results are similar if local general interest sources and government websites are included. After excluding government and general interest local news, 5.3% of the articles in the briefings could not be matched to MBFC scores.³⁴

³²Sources were categorized by first matching the sources to ABYZ News Links and manually filling in missing information. Where possible, sources were matched by URL host or domain. Where URLs were missing or not identifiable (e.g. link to video hosting service), I matched by source name. For more details about dropped news sources and articles, see Table A2.

³³News outlets that focus exclusively on local or state politics (e.g. the Oregon Capital Chronicle) are not considered general interest.

³⁴Partisan bias is missing for less than 6% of the articles in the DOI, DHS, and USCIS briefings, but the VA briefing is missing scores for 29.3% of articles. The VA briefing has more missing scores because it contains more news from smaller, specialized news outlets.

3.3. Agencies

By exploiting the structure of the DOI and DHS news briefings, I estimate news collection for 16 separate agencies.³⁵ Both the DHS and DOI are large cabinet agencies that oversee many smaller agencies, bureaus, and offices. Their briefings are broken into sections, and some of these sections are dedicated to specific subagencies (see Table 1). Thus, the DOI and DHS briefings can be used to estimate the news collection for 15 different agencies.

Estimates of DHS and DOI news collection use the whole briefing, including sections that do not correspond to a specific subagency (e.g. “top news”). Estimates for their subagencies use only the section of the briefing corresponding to the subagency. Because USCIS has its own dedicated section of the DHS news summary, the USCIS results are estimated twice. The first estimate is based on the separate USCIS news briefing. The second is based on the USCIS section of the DHS news briefing. The USCIS results suggest that the composition of a subagency’s briefing is reasonably similar to its section of the parent agency’s briefing. This is consistent with agency emails, where subagency staff discuss their input into the briefings.³⁶

To test whether agency ideology shapes news collection, I used agency ideology scores

³⁵The VA and USCIS briefings do not have any headings that correspond to sub-agencies. Headings may be dropped from individual briefings when there is no relevant news coverage. Because the DOI headings change partway through 2017, a Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA) section is only available for 2017-2018.

³⁶For example, in 2018, an employee from a DOI subagency emailed two directors, writing that she regularly sent the contractor (Bulletin Intelligence) specific articles to be included in the next day’s DOI news summary and invited them to also send “articles that are important to your mission and you think should be highlighted [in the main DOI briefing]” (Joshua, 2018).

from Richardson et al. (2018).³⁷ Their scores characterize the long-term policy views of government agencies and range from -2 to 2.³⁸ The sixteen agencies in my main analysis represent a wide range of ideology scores (-1.59 to 1.79).

3.4. News Supply (Media Cloud)

As previously described, the composition of the briefings is determined by the supply of news and the news selection process. To estimate the supply of news, I queried Media Cloud, an open-source collection of online news, for articles from US news sources that mention each agency name (Roberts et al., 2021). Because the coverage quality varies over time (see Appendix A.8), I do not use Media Cloud to compare news selection across presidential administrations. However, I find that the Media Cloud sample reliably captures cross-agency variation. Comparing across agencies reveals how news outlets allocate limited reporting resources during periods where data is available. As a robustness check, I also replicated

³⁷Richardson et al.’s (2018) scores were used because they are available for the most agencies. One other agency ideology measure is available for more than five agencies in my sample (Napolio, 2025), but its use of a large language model partially trained on news media raises concerns about reverse causality. Where possible, I have verified that my results replicate when using alternative measures of agency ideology (Chen & Johnson, 2015; Clinton & Lewis, 2008; Napolio, 2025).

³⁸Richardson et al. (2018) calculated these scores using a 2014 survey of political appointees and civil servants. Respondents were asked, “Some agencies have policy views due to law, practice, culture, or tradition that can be characterized across Democratic and Republican administrations as liberal or conservative. This can be an important feature of the environment of public management in these agencies (which is why we ask about it)...In your opinion, do the policy views of the following agencies tend to slant liberal, slant conservative, or neither consistently in both Democratic and Republican administrations?” (p. 304).

Table 1: Composition of briefing data. Sample sizes calculated after dropping local general interest sources and government websites.

Briefing	Agency	Agency Name	Part of Briefing	Years	Total Articles	Total Dates
DOI	DOI	Department of Interior	Whole	2015-2018	27,083	213
DOI	BLM	Bureau of Land Management	Section	2015-2018	525	210
DOI	FWS	Fish and Wildlife Service	Section	2015-2018	1,093	210
DOI	GS	US Geological Survey	Section	2015-2018	323	160
DOI	NPS	National Park Service	Section	2015-2018	1,505	212
DOI	BOR	Bureau of Reclamation	Section	2016-2018	94	104
DOI	BIA	Bureau of Indian Affairs	Section	2017-2018	232	128
VA	VA	Department of Veterans Affairs	Whole	2020-2021	2,386	233
USCIS	USCIS	US Citizenship and Immigration Service	Whole	2022-2025	26,773	922
DHS	DHS	Department of Homeland Security	Whole	2024-2025	61,446	655
DHS	CG	Coast Guard	Section	2024-2025	1,875	583
DHS	FEMA	Federal Emergency Management Agency	Section	2024-2025	5,243	643
DHS	SS	Secret Service	Section	2024-2025	1,980	567
DHS	TSA	Transportation Security Agency	Section	2024-2025	1,128	454
DHS	USCBP	Customs and Border Protection	Section	2024-2025	3,664	648
DHS	USCIS	US Citizenship and Immigration Service	Section	2024-2025	2,459	591
DHS	USICE	Immigration and Customs Enforcement	Section	2024-2025	6,414	618

the analysis using the Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone (GDELT), which is another large collection of online news.

4. Results

The following analysis evaluates whether agency news collection is balanced and, if not, whether the imbalance reflects biased selection or supply. I first examine whether the partisan composition of agency news briefings varies systematically by agency ideology. Although briefings appear ideologically skewed, I show that this pattern is driven by asymmetries in the supply of news rather than biased selection. I then examine whether partisan leaders shape news collection by analyzing changes across presidential transitions.

4.1. Variation across agencies

Is agency ideology associated with the partisan composition of news briefings?

To examine the relationship between the partisan content of the briefings and agency ideology, I calculate how often each briefing cites articles from a left-leaning, center, or right-leaning news sources.³⁹ For each partisan slant category, I create a separate subplot, comparing the proportion of articles in the category to agency ideology. Due to the structure of the US media market, the results should be particularly clear when comparing agency ideology to the amount of news from right-leaning news sources (Benkler et al., 2018; Guess, 2021). The scarcity of major center-right outlets makes it easier to differentiate center and right-leaning sources (see Figure A1).

The results in Figure 1 show a strong association between agency ideology and the partisan composition of the briefings. Conservative agencies collect more news from right-leaning sources and less news from center and left-leaning news sources, relative to more liberal agencies. As expected, this pattern is most evident in the ‘Right-leaning’ subplot. The best fit line ($\beta = 0.062$) is substantively large: comparing the most liberal to the most conservative agency, we would expect a 24.8 percentage point increase in right-leaning coverage.⁴⁰

As previously discussed, the partisan composition of briefings in Figure 1 is the product of the available supply of news and the news selection process. Given strong motives for comprehensive news selection, I expect the disparity in Figure 1 to be produced by an asymmetric supply of news, rather than biased selection.

³⁹In Figure 1, I drop articles from sources that could not be matched to partisan slant. The proportion of articles with missing partisan slant scores is generally low and unrelated to agency ideology (see Figure A2).

⁴⁰For regression tables and alternative regression specifications, see Appendix A.2.

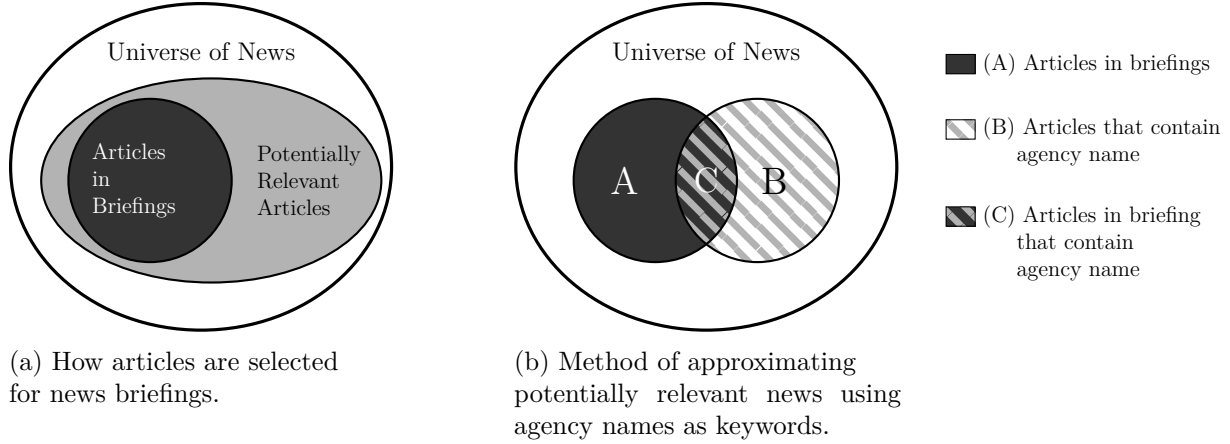


Figure 2: Diagram of agency news selection.

news sources cited in the briefings.⁴¹ While I could not identify all keywords used to define potentially relevant articles, the agency name is almost certainly one of these keywords.⁴² Figure 2 visualizes how querying agency names is used to approximate the set of potentially relevant news articles.

Figure 3 plots the partisan composition of the news supply.⁴³ Each subplot corresponds to different time periods and agencies. The first plot shows that composition of the briefings

⁴¹I excluded articles from Media Cloud if (1) the source domain never appeared in a briefing, (2) it came from a general interest local source or government website, or (3) it came from an international source, which includes sources based outside the US or primarily covering other countries. Major wire services (AP, Reuters, UPI) were not counted as international sources. Because other countries have similarly named agencies, a large number of articles from international sources were not relevant to US agencies.

⁴²During the contract solicitation process, a potential contractor asked, “Do you have a list of keywords to share?” and the DHS replied “We suggest including all component names and their jurisdiction as keywords to start” (Department of Homeland Security, 2018, p. 8).

⁴³For versions of Figure 3(i) and (ii) with the proportion of news from other partisan slant categories (center, left-leaning, and not categorized sources), see Appendix A.3.

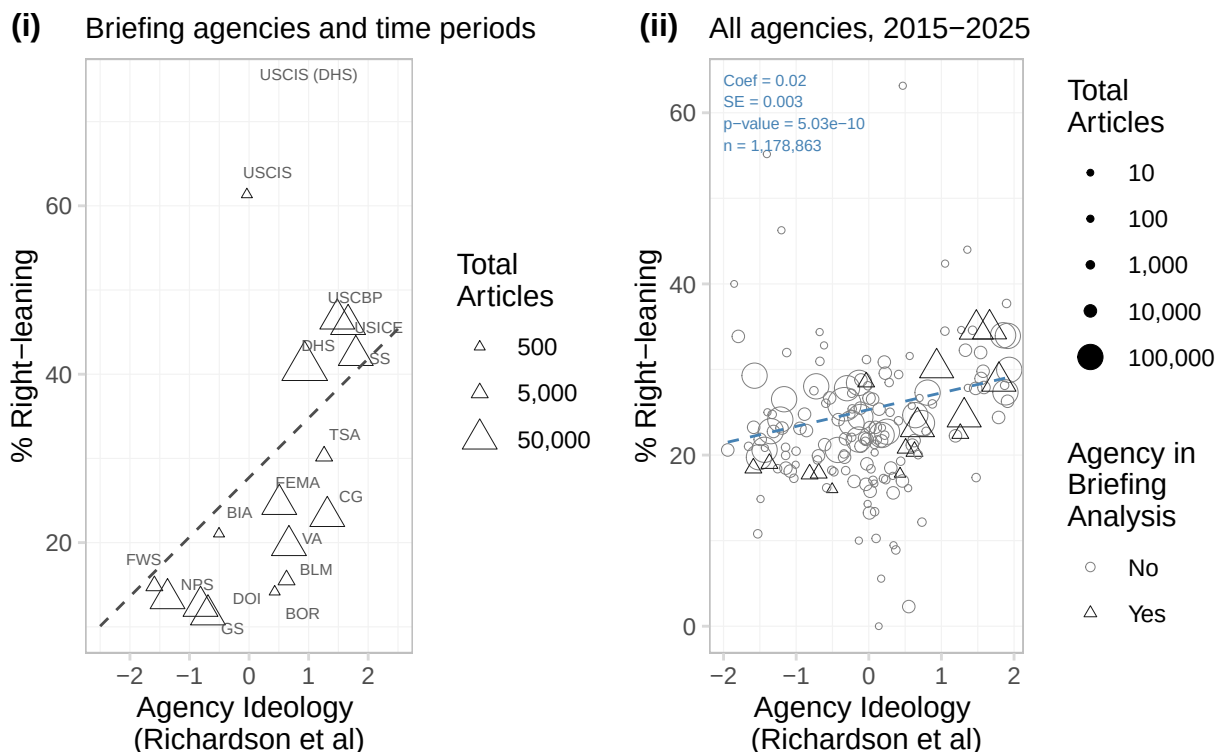


Figure 3: Supply of partisan news about government agencies. The subplots are generated using different sets of Media Cloud data: (i) articles about briefing agencies during time periods covered by briefings; (ii) articles about agencies with ideology scores during 85 randomly sampled weeks from 2015-2025. Standard errors calculated using heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors and clustering by agency, news source, and article URL.

can be explained by an unbalanced supply of news. The second plot shows that this supply-side asymmetry extends beyond the agencies and time periods in the briefings sample. For Figure 3(ii), I queried Media Cloud for all 165 agencies categorized in Richardson et al. (2018) over 85 randomly sampled weeks from January 2015 through May 2025.⁴⁴

To produce Figure 3(i), I queried Media Cloud for articles that mention the agencies in the briefing dataset during the time periods covered by the briefings.⁴⁵ For each agency, I

⁴⁴The weeks were selected using stratified random sampling and 6-month strata. An extra week was sampled from April 2025; removing it does not affect the results.

⁴⁵When I have a complete sample of briefings, I collect all news published between the first and last briefing in the sample. For the DOI and its subagencies, I subset the Media

then calculate the proportion of articles from right-leaning sources. The regression line shows the relationship between agency ideology and the amount of coverage an agency receives from right-leaning news outlets. If the conservative news sources preferentially cover conservative agencies or center/liberal sources preferentially cover liberal agencies, we will see a positive coefficient. Consistent with this supply-side explanation, Figure 3(i) reveals a strong positive relationship between agency ideology and the production of news ($\beta = 0.071$). Specifically, partisan news sources are more likely to publish news about ideologically-aligned agencies. Because Media Cloud does not monitor all sources in the briefings, Figure 3(i) is not directly comparable to Figure 1. To compare the supply-side disparity to the briefings, I recalculate the regression line from Figure 1 after dropping domains that are not collected by Media Cloud ($\beta = 0.075$). The effects are similar across measures: for a one-unit change in agency ideology, right-leaning outlets produce about 7.1 percentage points more coverage mentioning the agency by name and compose roughly 7.5 percentage points more of its news briefing.

In Figure 3(ii), I examine whether the asymmetries in Figures 1 and 3(i) are unique to the time periods and agencies in the briefing sample.⁴⁶ Examining the relationship between the supply of news and agency ideology does not require agency briefings, so I extended the Media Cloud queries to include all 165 agencies with ideology scores from Richardson et al. (2018) and 85 randomly sampled weeks from 2015-2025. For each agency, I then calculate the proportion of articles from right-leaning sources.

Figure 3(ii) reveals that there is a durable asymmetry in the supply of news and that it

Cloud results to articles in the window directly before the date of a briefing in the sample. The results replicate when the window size varies (see Appendix A.3).

⁴⁶As an additional robustness test, I replicate these results using 17 randomly sampled weeks (2017-2025) from a second publicly available media database, GDELT (Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone). I also reproduce the plot using other media slant measures from Guess (2021) and Allsides. See Appendix A.3.

extends beyond the 16 agencies in the briefing sample. To calculate the standard error of the regression line in Figure 3(ii), I clustered the standard errors by agency, news source, and article URL.⁴⁷ The plot shows a statistically-significant, positive relationship between an agency’s ideology and the amount coverage it receives from right-leaning news sources. Compared to the most liberal agencies, the most conservative agencies receive approximately 8 percentage points more news from right-leaning media sources ($\beta=0.02$, $se=0.003$, $p=5.03e-10$, $n=1,178,863$).⁴⁸ In Appendix A.4, I examine outlet-level heterogeneity, showing that left-leaning outlets generally produce more coverage of liberal agencies and right-leaning outlets generally produce more coverage of conservative agencies.

Is there evidence of preferential selection after controlling for the supply of news?

While the results in Figure 3 show that a supply asymmetry could explain the relationship in Figure 1, the analysis is not conclusive. To formally test whether there is any evidence of selection bias conditional on an article being published, I directly compared the briefings to potentially relevant articles published during the same period.⁴⁹

⁴⁷Each agency only has one ideology score, so the independent variable is assigned at the agency-level. Partisan slant is determined by the slant of the news source, so dependent variable is assigned at the source-level. Clustering by article URL addresses the non-independence of observations arising when a single article mentions multiple agencies. The Media Cloud query results are stacked such that an article can appear in the dataset multiple times, once for each agency name in the article. The final dataset contains 1,178,863 article-agency pairs, 889,440 unique URLs, 165 agencies, and 334 sources.

⁴⁸See Appendix A.3 for alternate regression specifications.

⁴⁹Like the previous analysis, I drop articles from Media Cloud if (1) the source domain never appeared in a briefing, (2) it came from a general interest local source or government website, or (3) it came from an international source. The results are similar if all local,

Referring back to Figure 2b, I collect the set of articles mentioning an agency’s name (Region B) and determine which articles were included in the news briefings (Region C). I then determine whether the included articles (Region C) are more likely to be from right-leaning news sources, compared to the other potentially-relevant articles (Region B).

For Figure 4, I match the Media Cloud dataset to the briefing data using the article publication date and domain.⁵⁰ The resulting ‘matched sample’ contains all published articles that mention each agency name and an outcome variable that is 1 if the article is matched to the briefings and 0 otherwise. If an article with the same news source and publication date could be found in the relevant briefing or section of briefing, all articles from that news source were counted as included.⁵¹ Because article URLs were available for about half of the agencies, I also matched by URL and used the results to validate the match quality (see Appendix A.5).⁵² I also verified that the URL matched sample produces similar results (see

government, and international sources are included in the regression.

⁵⁰Publication date is available for all Media Cloud articles and for 98.5 of the articles in the DHS, DOI, and USCIS briefings. Due to the structure of the VA briefings, the publication date could not be determined. When matched by URL, the VA results are also null (see Figure A19). To reduce false positives, I removed three national news sections from the DOI briefing before matching (e.g. “Top National News”).

⁵¹For example, when matching the Media Cloud results to the DHS briefing, I looked for a matching article anywhere in the briefing. For a subagency like FEMA, I only looked for a match in the FEMA section of the DHS briefing.

⁵²See Appendix A.6 for error rate estimates. Although URL matches are only possible for approximately half of the briefing sample, they can be used to test the validity of other matching strategies. Based on this error rate analysis, one source had an abnormally large false positive rate (yahoo.com) and has been dropped from Figure 4. Including yahoo.com does not substantively affect the results (see Figure A17).

Figures A17, A18, and A19).

Before testing for preferential selection, I used the URL matched sample to verify that agency names are a reasonable proxy for the keywords used to define the set of potentially relevant news (see Figure 2). For all but one agency, these tests support using agency names as keywords; however, they raise concerns about the representativeness of the USCIS results.⁵³ Due to these tests and the small size of the USCIS sample⁵⁴, the USCIS results should arguably be dropped. However, for transparency, I have included the USCIS results in Figure 4. Excluding the USCIS articles does not substantively affect the results (see Figure A17).

I performed two tests to verify that the articles mentioning an agency’s name are representative of all articles in the news briefing. First, I check that the results in Figure 1 replicate when the briefing sample is limited to articles mentioning agencies by name (Region C in Figure 2b). For all but one agency (USCIS), the results of this test suggest that the matched sample is representative. Second, I estimate how many articles in the briefings include an agency’s name. In other words, I compare the included articles (Region C) to all articles in the briefings (Region A). For most agencies, articles with agency names make up at least 13-50% of the briefing articles (see Table A7).⁵⁵ However, USCIS is mentioned in <1% of the articles in its briefing or section of the DHS briefing.

Formally, to test whether the slant of an outlet still affects its inclusion after accounting for supply, I use the following model: $Incl_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 S_i + \beta_2 I_i + \beta_3 (S_i \times I_i) + \epsilon$. For each

⁵³See Appendix A.6 for more details and robustness checks.

⁵⁴Over the whole USCIS briefing period from January 2022 through June 2025, Media Cloud identified 206 articles that mention the agency by name. Only 119 are from right-leaning sources, and most (61%) are from a single source (newsweek.com).

⁵⁵See Appendix A.6. Because some articles have multiple URLs, these numbers likely underestimate the number of briefing articles that mention an agency’s name.

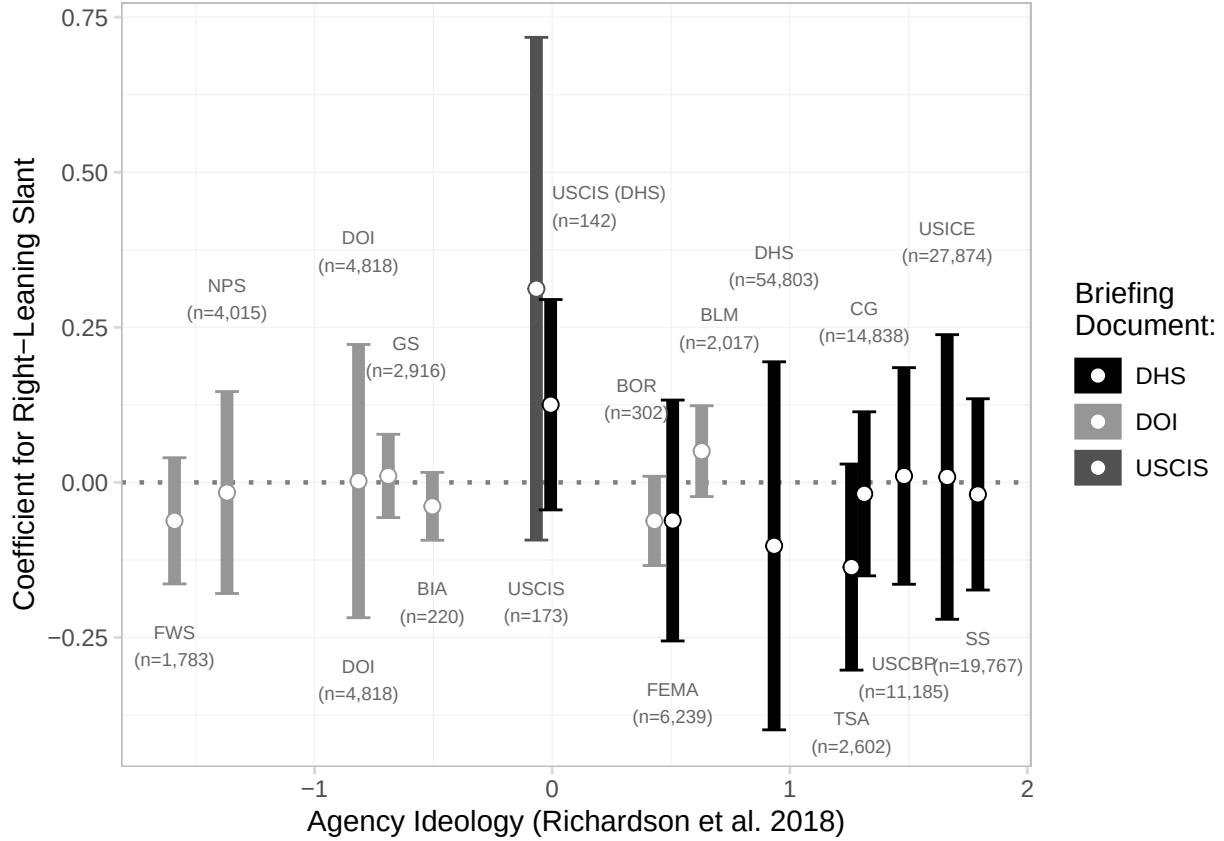


Figure 4: Estimated effect of right-leaning slant on the probability that an article is included in the news briefing. 95% confidence intervals. Models use OLS with robust standard errors clustered by news source and article URL. Outcome variable is binary indicator (1 if article included in news briefing, 0 otherwise). Independent variable is media slant; left-leaning sources are the reference category.

article i , $Incl_i$ is 1 if the article is included in the briefing, S_i is the slant of the news outlet, and I_i is the ideology of the agency mentioned in the article. If agencies are preferentially selecting articles from ideologically-aligned sources, the interaction between agency ideology and right-leaning slant (β_3) would be positive. In contrast, the results suggest a weak, possibly negative relationship. To test the robustness, I ran the regression with varying samples, matching methods, slant measures, and ideology measures. Across specifications, the interaction estimates are small, not significant, and negative (see Figures A17 and A18).

This null finding is evident in Figure 4. Instead of an interaction, I run a separate regression for each agency, $Incl_i = \beta_0 + \beta_R \text{Right}_i + \beta_C \text{Center}_i + \epsilon$, and plot the coefficient

for right-leaning news sources (β_R). A positive coefficient indicates that the agency is more likely to include articles from right-leaning sources, compared to left-leaning sources. A negative estimate indicates the opposite, and a value near zero suggests it is equally likely to include articles from left- or right-leaning sources.

In Figure 4, I arrange the coefficients by agency ideology. If agencies preferentially selected co-partisan news sources, we would expect the point estimates to be higher for more conservative agencies. Figure 4 shows that the estimates do not follow this pattern, providing no evidence of biased selection. When the results are matched by URL, the DHS and DHS subagency estimates in Figure 4 become even smaller (see Figure A19).⁵⁶

Collectively, the results yield three key findings. First, there is a strong association between an agency’s ideology and the extent to which it cites partisan news sources. Second, the supply asymmetry extends beyond the specific agencies and time periods included in the briefings data. Third, conditional on news publication, there is no evidence that liberal or conservative agencies prefer news from ideologically-aligned sources.

4.2. Variation across administrations

While agencies have strong motives that disincentivize preferential selection, individuals within an agency could impose their own preferences on the news selection process, particularly in the highly-partisan climate of current US politics. To test whether the preferences of agency staff shape news selection, I examine the partisan composition of the briefings across presidential transitions. Political appointees have input into contracting decisions and help administer the contracts, and presidential transitions affect the composition of agencies and their leadership (Bolton et al., 2021; Spenkuch et al., 2023).

Evidence of changes across presidential administrations is mixed. The proportion of conservative coverage in the DOI briefings remains relatively stable from 2015 through 2018,

⁵⁶Recall that URL matching was not possible for the DOI briefings.

including during the transition from Barack Obama to Donald Trump in 2017.⁵⁷ However, the DHS briefings underwent a dramatic change shortly after Trump took office in January 2025.

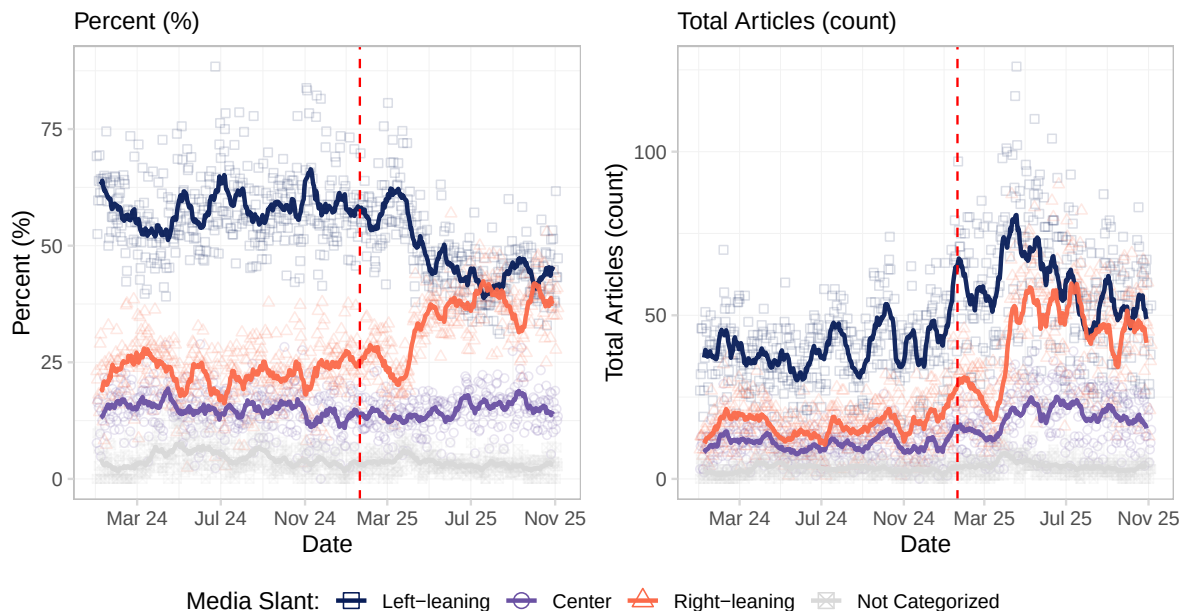


Figure 5: Over-time partisan composition of the DHS news briefings. Dotted line at Trump’s 2025 inauguration. Lines are 2-week rolling averages.

Beginning in late March 2025, DHS briefings began to incorporate much more right-leaning coverage (see Figure 5).⁵⁸ This change in composition that cannot be attributed solely to supply-side factors. Between January 2022 and March 2025, the DHS news briefings never cited certain far right news sources, including Breitbart, Newsmax, the Blaze, the Daily Wire, the Daily Caller, the Daily Signal, and the Federalist. Since April, all of these

⁵⁷See Figure A20. The VA briefings also show little change, but the available briefings stop about a month after Joe Biden’s inauguration.

⁵⁸The rightward shift appears when Figure 5 is reproduced using the alternative measures of media slant. See Figures A23 and A24. It also appears when local general interest sources and government websites are included (see Figure A22).

sources have been featured prominently.⁵⁹ Because these sources were never included in DHS briefings prior to March 2025, their addition cannot be attributed to changes in the news supply.⁶⁰ Additionally, the placement of conservative news also suggests preferential treatment. The shift towards conservative media is concentrated at the beginning of the news briefing (see Figure A21), which is where the most important stories are generally placed (Sullivan, 2012).

Interestingly, despite being housed under DHS, the balance of partisan coverage in the USCIS briefings follows a different pattern (see Figure A20). The aggregate long-term composition of the USCIS briefings changed less dramatically. However, upon closer examination, an anomalously large number of new right-leaning sources were also added around April and May 2025.⁶¹ In both the USCIS and DHS briefings, there is a clear deviation from the normal process of adding sources. In April and May, there is a spike in the number of new, ideologically extreme sources (see Figure A26). Notably, there is no equivalent spike in DOI or VA briefings.

⁵⁹For example, the top 10 DHS briefing sources after April include two far right sources that were never cited previously: Breitbart and Newsmax.

⁶⁰In order for supply to explain the number of newly added conservative sources, sources like Breitbart would need to have produced zero relevant news before March 2025. Using Media Cloud and the source websites, I verified that each of the 31 right-leaning sources added after April existed before 2025. Because some of these sources like Breitbart were included in the TechMIS-produced USCIS briefing before 2023, we know that TechMIS was collecting news from these sources before 2025.

⁶¹Starting in April, the USCIS briefings increasingly cite sources like Breitbart, Newsmax, the Blaze, the Daily Wire, the Federalist, One America News Network (OAN), and the Daily Signal. Interestingly, while some of these sources were occasionally cited during the Biden administration, they were rare and not cited after 2023.

In summary, leadership may affect the partisan content of the news summaries under some circumstances. Those circumstances were not present at DOI in 2017 but are present at DHS in 2025. Additional conservative news sources have also been appearing in the USCIS briefings, but these sources appear infrequently and contribute less to the aggregate balance of coverage.

5. Discussion

This paper examines how federal agencies collect information from the news and the consequences of these efforts. I first consider agencies as unitary actors, assessing patterns across the organization as a whole, and then examine individual incentives by looking at presidential transitions. The results suggest that agencies as a whole do not systematically prefer ideologically aligned news outlets. However, they raise important questions about the consequences of an asymmetric news supply and how agencies should approach news collection. While less conclusive, the recent changes to the DHS briefing suggest that agency leadership can influence news selection, particularly in highly politicized environments.

Importantly, this paper reveals that asymmetries in the supply of news are reflected in agency news exposure. To fully understand the consequences of asymmetric coverage, additional research will be needed on its origins and implications. Nevertheless, prior research on government decision making and partisan media suggest that the asymmetries in Figures 1 and 3 have important political and policy consequences. Examining this research also suggests directions for future research and provides insight into the normative implications of an asymmetric information supply.

Information about the existence of policy problems and demand for policy change has been shown to affect policy decisions and elite strategy. Collectively, this research suggests that differences in news content can affect policymaking when they affect judgement about public opinion or the existence, severity, and solutions to policy problems. The only previous

study of government news summaries (Karpowitz, 2009) used Richard Nixon’s handwritten notes to prove that information in the White House news briefings affected Nixon’s communications efforts, policy-making activity, personnel management, and emotional state. Studies have also linked news exposure to important judgement about public opinion (Broockman & Skovron, 2018; Furnas & LaPira, 2024), the existence of policy problems (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015), the importance of policy problems (Van Aelst & Walgrave, 2016; Walgrave & Van Aelst, 2006), the best solutions to policy problems (Jablonski & Seim, 2024), and the activities of other political actors (Cook, 1998). Beyond studies of media, information has been shown to affect elite decision making and responsiveness (Jablonski & Seim, 2024; Liaqat, 2019; Seim et al., 2020).

Turning to prior research on partisan media bias, existing research has established that left- and right-leaning sources produce different information. A large body of existing research has established that the partisan slant of a source shapes the information content of news by affecting story selection and presentation (Broockman & Kalla, 2025; Groeling, 2013; Grossman et al., 2022; Hosseinmardi et al., 2025; Larcinese et al., 2011; Mullainathan & Shleifer, 2005; Puglisi, 2011; Puglisi & Snyder Jr, 2011; Shultziner & Stukalin, 2021). This evidence is further bolstered by the results of this paper. The asymmetric supply of news shown in Figure 3 illustrates how right-leaning news sources produce more coverage of conservative agencies and less coverage of liberal agencies.

Future research should investigate the causes and consequences of the partisan asymmetry found in Figure 3. Compared to the dangers of asymmetric supply, more attention has been paid to the dangers of preferential news selection (e.g. Broockman & Kalla, 2025). Nevertheless, an asymmetric supply of news also raises concerns, particularly in the context of elite news consumption and given the size of the disparity. Some liberal agencies collect almost no coverage from conservative sources. If bureaucrats believe that the briefing collection process is unbiased, they may be less likely to recognize supply-driven limitations to their information environment. Being aware of bias has been shown to mitigate the effects

of bias (Lee, 2017). An incomplete information supply could increase the chances that the agency makes a strategic error, but it could also affect agency behavior in less visible ways, like forcing an agency to expend more resources on other types of information collection efforts. Unless they explicitly seek out conservative voices from other sources, liberal agencies will have less information about the thoughts and opinions of conservatives elsewhere in government and in the wider public.

Interestingly, outside of a few sectors like emergency communication, there has been limited prior research on how political elites should optimize media monitoring. The lack of clear guidance may explain why very few media monitoring contracts contain specific provisions for ensuring the balance of agency news briefings.⁶² Arguably, agencies should over-sample news from less common types of news. When combined with political sensitivities around news diversity, agency staff or the monitoring service itself may choose not to adopt more complex optimization strategies and instead favor basic heuristics like selecting news equally or in proportion to the news supply. Especially in the age of large language models and other technological advancements, future research should consider how to design government media monitoring strategies that efficiently capture the all information in news and inform staff about the limitations of news collection.

As expected, the complex motives behind agency news consumption disincentive agencies from preferentially seeking out co-partisan news; however, under some circumstances, the partisan preferences of powerful individuals within an agency can shape the selection process. Figure 5 reveals that the composition of DHS news briefings changed dramatically after Donald Trump returned to office. Under Kristi Noem’s leadership, coverage from far-right news sources has increased in volume and prominence. While Figure 5 shows a dramatic and

⁶²Only one contract contains quotas or other provisions for ensuring source diversity, and its quotas apply to the geographic diversity of local news coverage (Consumer Product Safety Commission, 2020). None of the contracts require that contractors monitor an ideologically-diverse set of sources.

persistent change, the briefings alone cannot conclusively identify the cause of this change. There are several possible explanations, some of which are consistent with the agency’s overall preferences while others require the priorities of agency leadership dominate other motives for news collection.

First, the new administration could make different judgements about the value of news to the agency as a whole. Not all sources are created equally. In order to create a quickly digestible and representative picture of the news, agencies might choose to prioritize information based on factors like source popularity, influence, or accuracy. Agencies may also choose to exclude low-value information when the cost of including it is too high. Agencies may choose to remove particularly offensive or false information from a document circulated widely within an agency. Given the DOJ’s decision to fire TechMIS over an antisemitic blog (Barrett, 2019), contractors themselves may adjust content to avoid controversy or termination. Individual judgements of value or cost are influenced by personal attributes like partisan affiliation (Bhuiyan et al., 2020; Ladd & Podkul, 2018) as well as the broader political environment. For example, it may be particularly valuable to have sources monitored by the president, even if they contain offensive or false information.

Alternatively, political leaders may impose their own preferences on the briefings, at the expense of other constituencies within the agency. Most obviously, agency leadership may see these briefings as an opportunity to advance a political agenda by shaping the information environment of other leadership and staff. The EPA’s dispute with Bulletin Intelligence during the first Trump administration suggests that leaders might also seek to insulate themselves from negative coverage (Benton, 2017; Choma & Leber, 2016; Dravis et al.; Ericksen, 2017a; Leber et al., 2017).

While there are legitimate reasons for restricting or expanding collection of extreme or low-quality news, the changes at DHS raise concerns. Concentrating news from highly-partisan news outlets known for disseminating inaccurate information in the ‘top news’ section of the briefings suggests that current DHS leadership is not simply seeking more diverse

sources of information. At a critical time in US immigration policy, the prominence of relatively extreme conservative news sources may both reflect and reinforce the administration’s priorities.

Recent changes to news briefings reflect a broader pattern of politicizing information and manipulating access to media coverage. For decades, the government’s extensive efforts to collect, curate, and distribute news drew little outside notice. That changed when these once-routine practices came under heightened political scrutiny. In the early months of his second administration, President Donald J. Trump and his team devoted significant attention to government news consumption and payments for news services, going so far as to cancel widely used services from Politico and other news service providers.⁶³ This paper highlights a consequence of these actions. These decisions were not merely symbolic; they actively obstructed and politicized the supply of information flowing to government agencies.⁶⁴

Together, the findings of this paper show that even when agencies generally do not select ideologically congenial news, they operate within an information environment shaped by substantial partisan asymmetries in the supply of coverage. Additionally, under certain circumstances, choices by agency leadership can also alter the balance of information available to government staff. These results underscore the need for continued research on information collection within bureaucracies and how informational disparities affect their decision

⁶³In addition to targeting Politico, Trump’s administration has also explored cancelling other center- and left-leaning news subscriptions (Basu & Caputo, 2025; Guardian Staff, 2025) and taken steps to limit access to news at the Social Security agency (Sheffey, 2025).

⁶⁴In fact, by December 2025, the Trump administration began to quietly reverse its decision to cancel key media contracts. Agencies “raised concerns about losing information when the White House initially requested cancellations,” and the White House itself remarked that “unfortunately we are forced to read the Fake News so we know what lies we have to debunk” (Kornfield et al., 2025).

making.

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